5. The Zen of Opening the Batting

The effective distance between batsman and bowler when a ball is delivered is approximately 17.68 metres. When Shoaib Akhtar releases it at around 160 kph, there is fractionally less than four-tenths of a second in which to react. Whatever you do, don’t blink, because that will waste a tenth of a second.

This means that, in the time it takes for a hummingbird to flap its wings about forty times, or a beam of light to cover in the region of 75,000 miles, you must read the ball out of the hand, judge the line and length, and detect, if possible, the degree of revolution. Talk about multitasking. It’s not the moment to realize you left your keys in the car.

Not all bowlers are the same, of course. There’s no one way to do what they do. Spinners are the three-card-trick merchants of the game. Sometimes, you can’t pick them, no matter how long or how intently you study the video. You need human contact to read any clues in body language. You watch in real time to see which way the ball is revolving. No matter how good the bowler is, he can’t release the ball so that it spins in an entirely different direction halfway down the wicket.

It’s not like being in the nets, where you have the freedom to play attacking shots against slower bowlers. You are simply not going to run down the wicket and try to hit them out of the park the moment you see them, because of the pressure of the situation. To play spin well, you attack on your terms, and that requires trust in your ability to defend well.